

The Three Essentials

Sunscreen. Retinol. Hyaluronic acid.

I am a board certified allergist, and the question I get asked most has nothing to do with medication. It is some version of: what is actually worth putting on my skin? This is that answer. Not ten steps, not a \$200 serum. Three products, used consistently.

Sunscreen protects the barrier you already have. Retinol is the one active with real evidence behind it for renewal, but it makes skin more sensitive to sun while you use it. Hyaluronic acid holds the water both of those need so skin is not left raw in the process. Each one covers a gap the other two leave open.

01 SUNSCREEN

Clinique Moisture Surge Sheer Hydrator, SPF 28

[Shop it](#)

Broad spectrum protection built into your moisturizer, so it is the step you actually do every morning instead of the one you skip. Sheer enough to go under makeup without pilling.

02 RETINOL

Clinique Smart Night Clinical MD Repair Treatment

[Shop it](#)

The one active worth being consistent about. Two nights a week to start, building up only as skin tolerates it. Give it twelve weeks before you judge it, and wear the SPF above non-negotiably.

03 HYALURONIC ACID

Clinique Moisture Surge 100H Auto-Replenishing Hydrator

[Shop it](#)

Hyaluronic acid pulls water into skin and holds it there for up to 100 hours. This is what actually fixes dehydrated, tight-feeling skin, not another cleanser.

THE ORDER I WOULD ACTUALLY DO IT

1. Start with the SPF. Every morning, rain or shine. This is the one non-negotiable.
2. Add the hydrator. Morning and night, without thinking about it.
3. Add retinol last, at night only, two nights a week, and never without the SPF.
4. Change one thing at a time, or you will not learn which change mattered.

Three words on the label. Only one is checkable.

This is the part nobody explains, and it is worth more than any single product on the page before this one.

Hypoallergenic NOT REGULATED

There is no standard behind it and no test a product has to pass. The FDA says plainly that no federal standards or definitions govern the word. It is the term people trust most and the one that tells you least.

Unscented OFTEN MISLEADING

A product can be unscented and still contain fragrance, added specifically to mask the smell of the other ingredients. If you react to fragrance, this word does not protect you.

Fragrance free CHECKABLE

It means none was added, and you can confirm it on the ingredient list. This is the term dermatologists tell patients to look for. Together with allergy tested, it is what I look for too.

HOW TO USE THIS

Nothing here treats a condition. If your skin is genuinely inflamed, or you have eczema or hives that are not controlled, that is a conversation with your own physician, not a shopping list. What this list does is reduce what your skin has to deal with in the first place.

WHERE THE REST OF IT LIVES

The full edit, including sun cover, what to sleep in, the bedroom and air changes that matter most, and what I actually wear to work, is at laurenfine.com/recommendations.

More of it arrives by email in The Permission to Change Edit: what is working, what I returned, and the small changes that make a day feel lighter. Sign up at laurenfine.com/join.

Some links here are affiliate links. If you make a purchase through one, I may earn a small commission at no extra cost to you. Nothing here is sponsored, no brand has paid to be included, and no company reviewed this before it went out. These are products I recommend and use.